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Eastern Bluebird

*Sialia sialis***QUICK STATS**

Length	6.3 – 8.3 in (16 – 21 cm)
Wingspan	9.8 – 12.6 in (25 – 32 cm)
Weight	1.0 – 1.1 oz (28 – 32 g)
Lifespan	Up to 10 years (avg. 2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Eastern Bluebird is one of the most beloved birds in North America — a small thrush whose brilliant royal-blue back, warm chestnut breast, and pure white belly create one of the most beautiful color combinations in the natural world. Henry David Thoreau wrote that "the bluebird carries the sky on his back," a description that remains apt. Once in severe decline due to competition from introduced House Sparrows and European Starlings for nest cavities, the Eastern Bluebird staged one of the most dramatic conservation comebacks in North American history — driven almost entirely by the efforts of volunteers erecting nest box trails across the continent.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Eastern Bluebird is found year-round across the eastern United States, from the Great Plains east to the Atlantic coast, and from southern Canada south to Nicaragua. Northern populations are partially migratory, moving south in winter. It inhabits open country with scattered trees: orchards, golf courses, roadsides, parks, open woodlands, pastures with fence posts, and suburban gardens with short grass and nearby trees. It is a cavity nester that depends entirely on pre-existing holes in trees or nest boxes.

DIET & FEEDING

- Live or dried mealworms — the single most effective food offering
- Wild berries: holly, dogwood, viburnum, pokeweed, Virginia creeper
- Insects and earthworms — the dominant food in warm months
- Bluebird-specific feeders with mealworm dishes
- Small fruits: serviceberry, hackberry, wild grape
- Rarely visits seed feeders — mealworms are essential

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Eastern Bluebirds are gentle, sociable birds that form family groups through the breeding season, with offspring from earlier broods sometimes helping feed their younger siblings. In winter they gather in loose flocks of 10–20 birds that roam open country in search of berry crops. They hunt insects by perching on a low branch or fence post, scanning the ground below, then dropping to capture prey — a hunting style called "drop-hunting" or "flycatching from a perch." They communicate with each other constantly using soft, melodious warbling calls that carry a quality of gentle contentment.

NESTING & BREEDING

Eastern Bluebirds are cavity nesters, using old woodpecker holes and nest boxes. The female builds a neat cup of grasses and pine needles inside the cavity. Clutches of 4–6 pale blue (or occasionally white) eggs are incubated by the female for 13–16 days. Both parents and sometimes helper birds feed the nestlings, which fledge at 17–21 days. Pairs raise 2–3 broods per season. Aggressive monitoring and eviction of House Sparrows from nest boxes is essential for bluebird nesting success.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Eastern Bluebird's song is a soft, rich, melodious warble — a series of flowing phrases with a gentle, liquid quality. It is one of the most pleasant sounds of early spring in eastern North America, beginning on warm late-winter days. The call is a distinctive, soft "tru-ly" or "chur-wi" whistle that is easily recognized once learned. Males sing persistently from exposed perches throughout the breeding season.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Increasing
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The Eastern Bluebird population is estimated at 22 million individuals and has increased dramatically since the 1970s, rebounding from severe mid-20th-century declines. This recovery is one of the great citizen science success stories — driven by thousands of volunteers maintaining nest box trails across the continent. Installing and actively managing nest boxes remains the single most impactful action any individual can take for this species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Offer live or dried mealworms in a shallow dish feeder near open grass
- Use a bluebird-specific feeder with a small entry hole to exclude starlings
- Install a nest box (1.5-inch entrance) on a post in open area, 5 ft high
- Monitor boxes weekly — evict House Sparrow nests immediately
- Plant native berry-producing shrubs: holly, dogwood, and serviceberry

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Back & wings (male)	Brilliant royal blue
Breast & flanks (male)	Rich chestnut-orange
Belly (male)	White
Female — back	Blue-gray with blue tinge on wings
Female — breast	Pale orange-buff, washed
Bill	Short, slightly curved, dark

COLOR ME!

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